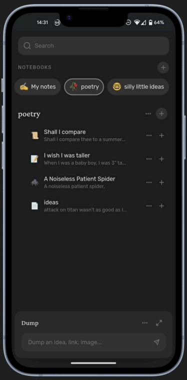
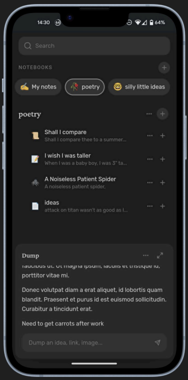

14:31
64%
Search
NOTEBOOKS
My notes
poetry
silly little ideas
poetry
Shall I compare
Shall I compare thee to a summer...
I wish I was taller
When I was a baby boy, I was 3" ta...
A Noiseless Patient Spider
A noiseless patient spider,
ideas
attack on titan wasn't as good as I...
Dump
Dump an idea, link, image...


14:30
64%
Search
NOTEBOOKS
My notes
poetry
silly little ideas
poetry
Shall I compare
Shall I compare thee to a summer...
I wish I was taller
When I was a baby boy, I was 3" ta...
A Noiseless Patient Spider
A noiseless patient spider,
ideas
attack on titan wasn't as good as I...
Dump
Dump an idea, link, image...

faucibus ut. Ut magna ipsum, iaculis et tristique id, porttitor vitae mi.

Donec volutpat diam a erat aliquet, id lobortis quam blandit. Praesent et purus id est euismod sollicitudin. Curabitur a tincidunt erat.

Need to get carrots after work

Dumpy

Notetaking app: *Dumpy*

When an idea strikes, things can get frantic.
Frustrated with the friction of other note-taking apps,
I designed Dumpy.

Personal project • Nov 2025 - Apr 2026 • UX/UI/Research

1. Overview > 2. Empathise > 3. Define > 4. Low-fi Prototype >
5. High-fi Prototype > 6. Finalising > 7. Learning

1. Overview

The problem is...

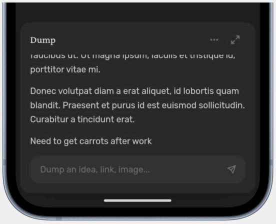
I'm a person who loves to take notes. I feel a responsibility to capture all my fleeting little ideas, silly and serious, comprehensive and not. **The ideas can be fleeting,** and if there's much standing between me and the sweet, secure permanence of a written note, **it can be gone forever.**

For me, **mobile apps have always been better than real notebooks.** I don't always have a notebook on me, or a pen, or a pen that works, but I do always have my phone.
Over the years, I've relied heavily on my phones' native note-taking apps, **Apple Notes** (2016-2019) and **Google Keep** (2019-Present).

I've always been frustrated at the (i) amount of friction and (ii) the lack of organisation that these apps have provided.
It takes far too many taps to take a note, and when you do, you bury the old ones. Open the app, locate a relevant note or create a new one, and throw the idea onto a page you would be lucky to ever find again.

...too much friction,
not enough organisation.

The solution is...



Dump

faucibus ut. Ut magna ipsum, iaculis et tristique id, porttitor vitae mi.

Donec volutpat diam a erat aliquet, id lobortis quam blandit. Praesent et purus id est euismod sollicitudin. Curabitur a tincidunt erat.

Need to get carrots after work

Dump an idea, link, image...

...less friction...

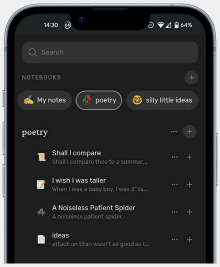
Dumpy treats the rapid capture of ideas as the primary use case. The key to the app's success is its key feature: **The Dump.**

The Dump lets users take a quick note in just a tap. You can then sort your notes out later, in a less stressful situation, or simply let it stack up.

...and more organisation.

Dumpy is hierarchically structured from the word-up. Paragraphs are nested in notes, which are nested in notebooks. **Users have phenomenal power to organise their notes how they like.**

The Dump can be a mess, so it's easy to move all of it, or parts of it, to other notes, or new notes.



14:30
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A Noiseless Patient Spider
A noiseless patient spider,

ideas
attack on titan wasn't as good as I...

2. Empathise

How do people take notes?
-- User Interviews.

I conducted 4 user interviews to answer this question.

The pre-installed notes apps weren't enough.

- They weren't reliable enough, or weren't functional enough, or weren't convenient enough. Some users used non--digital solutions.

People use whatever is convenient in the moment.

- Users message themselves on chat apps because of their speedy setup.

Every idea gets a new note.

- This gets messy, and users felt that their notes weren't navigable.

Users want a scratchpad.

- Users want a low-stakes place to keep temporary notes.

Users rely on notifications.

- Reminders are imperative for making a note app useful and reliable.

What are the enemy up to?
-- Competitive Audit.

I conducted a competitive audit of Evernote, Google Keep and Notion.

They had ideas worth stealing:

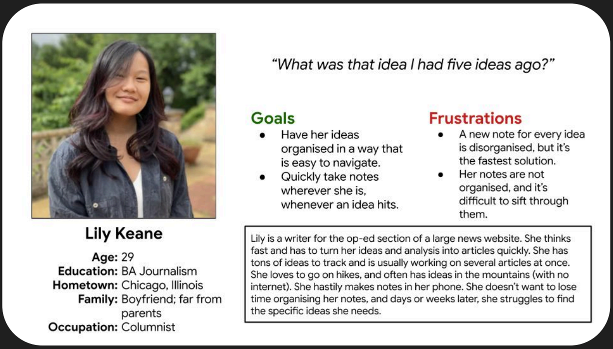
- Notion's impressively flexible 'block' system creates clear and powerful hierarchy.
- Evernote's 'Scratchbook' lets users quickly take a note on their home page.
- Other apps make great use of widgets to speed up note-taking.
- Great ability to customise notes to make them stand out, especially on Notion (emoji icons, serif-toggle, note titles...)

and some stuff to avoid:

- Always-online requirements; users in interviews said that this was undesirable.
- Maximum character limits on notes, and paywalls on the number of notes and folders you can make.
- Overly-complicated integration of features like text style manipulation and image insertion/resizing.

Personas

These personas allowed me to imagine end-users to design for. Meet the frantic, fast-brained journalist, Lily, and the highly-sociable polyglot, Alan.



Lily Keane

Age: 29
Education: BA Journalism
Hometown: Chicago, Illinois
Family: Boyfriend; far from parents
Occupation: Columnist

"What was that idea I had five ideas ago?"

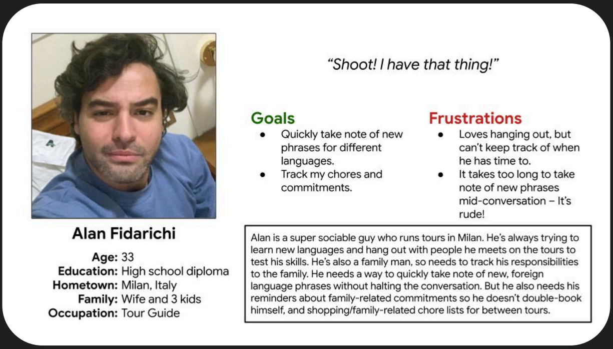
Goals

- Have her ideas organised in a way that is easy to navigate.
- Quickly take notes wherever she is, whenever an idea hits.

Frustrations

- A new note for every idea is disorganised, but it's the fastest solution.
- Her notes are not organised, and it's difficult to sift through them.

Lily is a writer for the op-ed section of a large news website. She thinks fast and has to turn her ideas and analysis into articles quickly. She has tons of ideas to track and is usually working on several articles at once. She loves to go on hikes, and often has ideas in the mountains (with no internet). She hastily makes notes in her phone. She doesn't want to lose time organising her notes, and days or weeks later, she struggles to find the specific ideas she needs.



Alan Fidarichi

Age: 33
Education: High school diploma
Hometown: Milan, Italy
Family: Wife and 3 kids
Occupation: Tour Guide

"Shoot! I have that thing!"

Goals

- Quickly take note of new phrases for different languages.
- Track my chores and commitments.

Frustrations

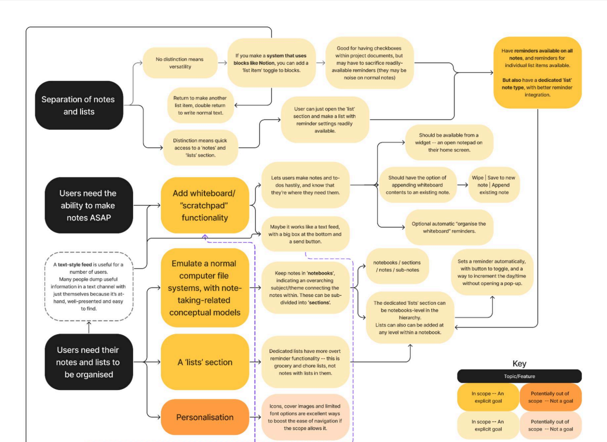
- Loves hanging out, but can't keep track of when he has time to.
- It takes too long to take note of new phrases mid-conversation – It's rude!

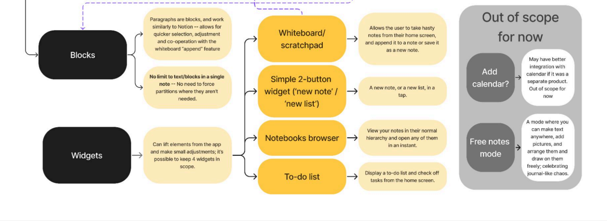
Alan is a super sociable guy who runs tours in Milan. He's always trying to learn new languages and hang out with people he meets on the tours to test his skills. He's also a family man, so needs to track his responsibilities to the family. He needs a way to quickly take note of new, foreign language phrases without halting the conversation. But he also needs his reminders about family-related commitments so he doesn't double-book himself, and shopping/family-related chore lists for between tours.

3. Define

The initial feature list

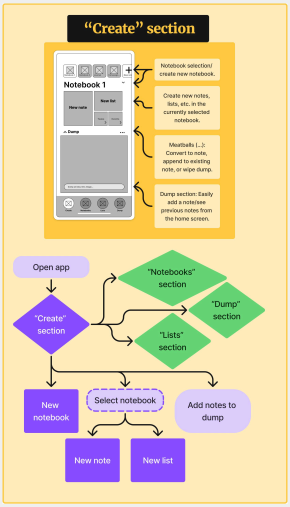
I built up a map of the best ideas from the Empathise phase to coalesce them into a more concrete image of the scope and structure of the initial product.

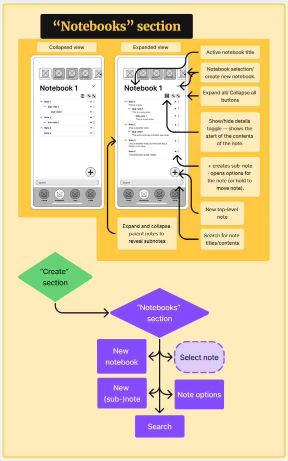

Separation of notes and lists
No distinction means versatility
If you make a system that uses blocks like Notion, you can add a 'list item' toggle to blocks.
Good for having checkboxes within project documents, but may have to sacrifice readily-available reminders (they may be noise on normal notes)
Have reminders available on all notes, and reminders for individual list items available.
But also have a dedicated 'list' note type, with better reminder integration.
Return to make another list item, double return to write normal text.
User can just open the 'list' section and make a list with reminder settings readily available.
Distinction means quick access to a 'notes' and 'lists' section.
Should be available from a widget -- an open notepad on their home screen.
Users need the ability to make notes ASAP
Add whiteboard/ "scratchpad" functionality
Lets users make notes and to-dos hastily, and know that they're where they need them.
Should have the option of appending whiteboard contents to an existing note.
Wipe | Save to new note | Append existing note
Optional automatic "organise the whiteboard" reminders.
Maybe it works like a text feed, with a big box at the bottom and a send button.
A text-style feed is useful for a number of users. Many people dump useful information in a text channel with just themselves because it's at-hand, well-presented and easy to find.
Emulate a normal computer file systems, with note-taking-related conceptual models
Keep notes in 'notebooks', indicating an overarching subject/theme connecting the notes within. These can be sub-divided into 'sections'.
notebooks / sections / notes / sub-notes
Sets a reminder automatically, with button to toggle, and a way to increment the day/time without opening a pop-up.
The dedicated 'lists' section can be notebooks-level in the hierarchy. Lists can also can be added at any level within a notebook.
Users need their notes and lists to be organised
A 'lists' section
Dedicated lists have more overt reminder functionality -- this is grocery and chore lists, not notes with lists in them.
Personalisation
Icons, cover images and limited font options are excellent ways to boost the ease of navigation if the scope allows it.
Key
Topic/Feature
In scope -- An explicit goal
Potentially out of scope -- Not a goal
In scope -- An explicit goal
Potentially out of scope -- Not a goal

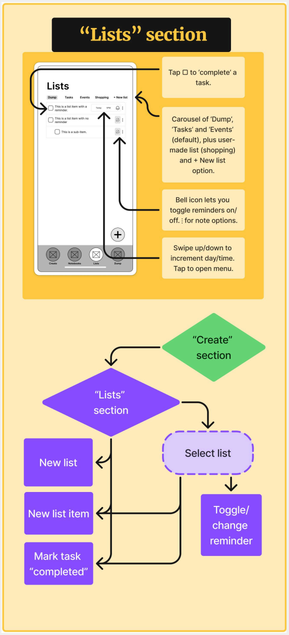

Blocks
Paragraphs are blocks, and work similarly to Notion -- allows for quicker selection, adjustment and co-operation with the whiteboard "append" feature
No limit to text/blocks in a single note -- No need to force partitions where they aren't needed.
Widgets
Can lift elements from the app and make small adjustments; it's possible to keep 4 widgets in scope.
Whiteboard/ scratchpad
Allows the user to take hasty notes from their home screen, and append it to a note or save it as a new note.
Simple 2-button widget ('new note' / 'new list')
A new note, or a new list, in a tap.
Notebooks browser
View your notes in their normal hierarchy and open any of them in an instant.
To-do list
Display a to-do list and check off tasks from the home screen.
Out of scope for now
Add calendar?
May have better integration with calendar if it was a separate product. Out of scope for now
Free notes mode
A mode where you can make text anywhere, add pictures, and arrange them and draw on them freely; celebrating journal-like chaos.

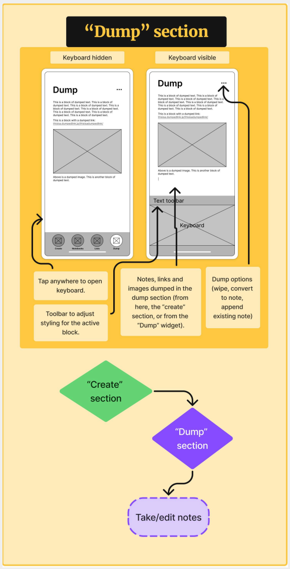
Wireframe-ing

My main idea at this point was to build an app around four major sections: 'Create', 'Notebooks', 'List', and 'Dump' -- a similar structure to Evernote.


"Create" section
Notebook 1
New note
New list
Tasks
Events
Dump
Notebook selection/ create new notebook.
Create new notes, lists, etc. in the currently selected notebook.
Meatballs (...): Convert to note, append to existing note, or wipe dump.
Dump section: Easily add a note/see previous notes from the home screen.
Open app
"Create" section
"Notebooks" section
"Dump" section
"Lists" section
New notebook
Select notebook
Add notes to dump
New note
New list


"Notebooks" section
Collapsed view
Expanded view
Notebook 1
Notebook 1
Active notebook title
Notebook selection/ create new notebook.
Expand all/ Collapse all buttons
Show/hide details toggle -- shows the start of the contents of the note.
+ creates sub-note ⋮ opens options for the note (or hold to move note).
New top-level note
Search for note titles/contents
Expand and collapse parent notes to reveal subnotes
"Create" section
"Notebooks" section
New notebook
Select note
New (sub-)note
Note options
Search


"Lists" section
Lists
Dump
Tasks
Events
Shopping
+ New list
Tap ☐ to 'complete' a task.
Carousel of 'Dump', 'Tasks' and 'Events' (default), plus user-made list (shopping) and + New list option.
Bell icon lets you toggle reminders on/ off. ⋮ for note options.
Swipe up/down to increment day/time. Tap to open menu.
"Create" section
"Lists" section
Select list
New list
New list item
Toggle/ change reminder
Mark task "completed"


"Dump" section
Keyboard hidden
Keyboard visible
Dump
Dump
Text toolbar
Keyboard
Tap anywhere to open keyboard.
Toolbar to adjust styling for the active block.
Notes, links and images dumped in the dump section (from here, the "create" section, or from the "Dump" widget).
Dump options (wipe, convert to note, append existing note)
"Create" section
"Dump" section
Take/edit notes

User testing (round 1)

I conducted 4 user tests to gather initial reactions to these wireframes before developing further. This helped me catch some *crucial* problems with the initial idea.

Too many things were similar but different.

- There was confusion around why lists and notes were different and even in different sections. Users were unsure what the Dump even was if it was just a kind of note.
- Some elements looked similar but did different things, causing confusion.

The Dump wasn't presented well.

- To repeat, users couldn't figure out what made the Dump special.
- It was present in two places, making it overly prominent and puzzled users.

So the next steps were to...

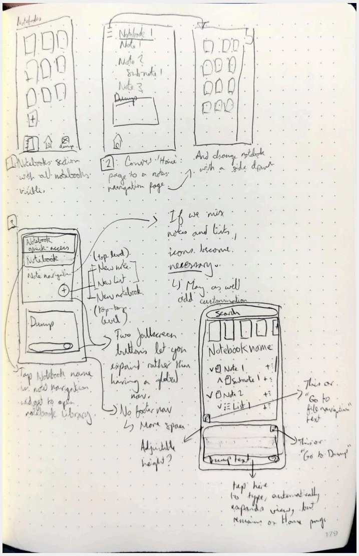
Consolidate or remove similar features.

- The goal was to reduce the app from four screens to just one.
- Lists should have been possible within notes to start with. The Dump worked great on the Create screen, so its section could be removed. The Create screen was suddenly made redundant.

Rework the Dump's presentation.

- Since it was the key selling point of the app, I chose to rework rather than remove it.
- It should explain itself clearly since it isn't something users will be used to.

Reworking


Notebooks
Notebook 1
Note 1
Note 2
Sub-note 1
Note 3
~~Dump~~
dump
1 Notebooks section with all notebooks visible.
2 Convert 'Home' page to a notes navigation page
And change notebook with a side drawer
If we mix notes and lists, icons become necessary.
↳ May as well add customization
Notebook quick-access
Notebook
Note navigation
(top level)
New note
New list
New notebook
(top-top level)
Dump
Two fullscreen buttons let you expand rather than having a global nav.
Tap Notebook name in nav navigation widget to open notebook library
No footer nav
↳ More space
Search
Notebook name
Note 1
Subnote 1
Note 2
List 1
This or "Go to file navigation" text
This or "Go to Dump"
Adjustable height?
Dump text
tap here to type, automatically expands view, but remains on Home page
179

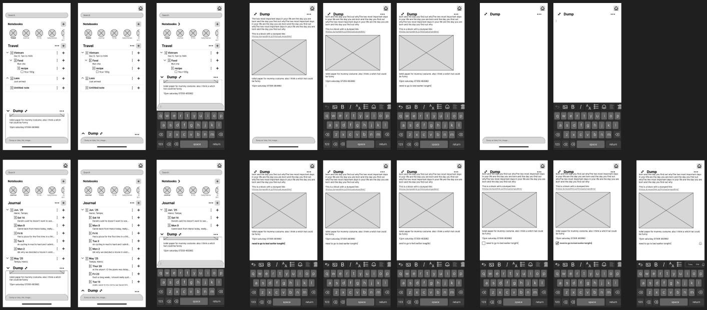
I played with reducing the app down with these paper wireframes.

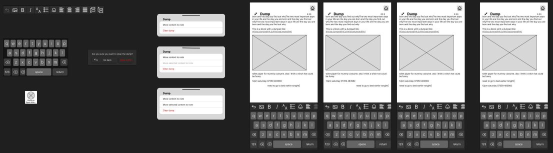
On the top half, I'm exploring the idea of a "drawer" with all the user's notebooks in it, but it seemed cumbersome -- users probably wouldn't need a full page for their notebooks anyway.

On the bottom right, I whittle the drawer down and come up with a four-level, one-page solution. The search bar at the top, then the notebooks section, with tabs for notebooks along the top, and the Dump beneath it all.

The Dump is now variably sized depending on context.

4. Low-fi Prototype





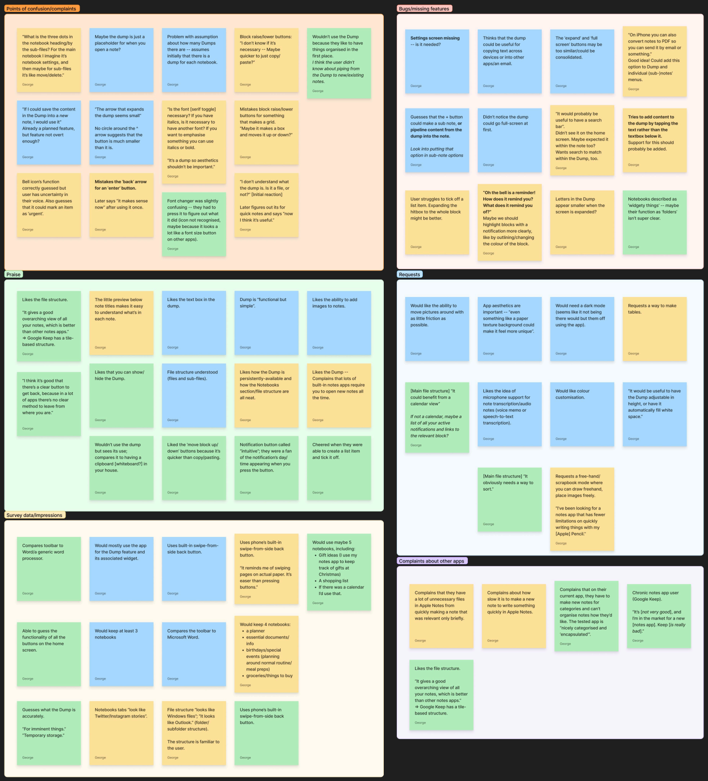
Click here to try the prototype

This prototype was constructed to test:
(i) the new variable-size Dump and its different states
(ii) the implementation of text styling tools in the text editor, accessible from the full-screen Dump
(iii) users' overall comprehension of the hierarchy and layout of the app and its file navigation structure.

I also used a temporary "Home" button in the corner to allow users to restart the prototype at any point during a test.

User testing (round 2)

I conducted 3 user tests with this prototype. I read from a script and urged them to think out loud as they worked through a number of tasks. I arranged their thoughts in an affinity diagram:



Points of confusion/complaints

"What is the three dots in the notebook heading/by the sub-files? For the main notebook I imagine it's notebook settings, and then maybe for sub-files it's like move/delete."
George

Maybe the dump is just a placeholder for when you open a note?
George

Problem with assumption about how many Dumps there are -- assumes initially that there is a dump for each notebook.
George

Block raise/lower buttons: "I don't know if it's necessary -- Maybe quicker to just copy/paste?"
George

Wouldn't use the Dump because they like to have things organised in the first place.
I think the user didn't know about piping from the Dump to new/existing notes.
George

"If I could save the content in the Dump into a *new* note, I would use it"
Already a planned feature, but feature not overt enough?
George

"The arrow that expands the dump seems small"

No circle around the ^ arrow suggests that the button is much smaller than it is.
George

"Is the font [serif toggle] necessary? If you have italics, is it necessary to have another font? If you want to emphasise something you can use italics or bold.

"It's a dump so aesthetics shouldn't be important."
George

Mistakes block raise/lower buttons for something that makes a grid.
"Maybe it makes a box and moves it up or down?"
George

Bell icon's function correctly guessed but user has uncertainty in their voice. Also guesses that it could mark an item as 'urgent'.
George

Mistakes the 'back' arrow for an 'enter' button.

Later says "it makes sense now" after using it once.
George

Font changer was slightly confusing -- they had to press it to figure out what it did (icon not recognised, maybe because it looks a lot like a font size button on other apps).
George

"I don't understand what the dump is. Is it a file, or not?" [Initial reaction]

Later figures out its for quick notes and says "now I think it's useful."
George

Bugs/missing features

Settings screen missing -- is it needed?
George

Thinks that the dump could be useful for copying text across devices or into other apps/an email.
George

The 'expand' and 'full screen' buttons may be too similar/could be consolidated.
George

"On iPhone you can also convert notes to PDF so you can send it by email or something."
Good idea! Could add this option to Dump and individual (sub-)notes' menus.
George

Guesses that the + button could make a sub note, **or pipeline content from the dump into the note.**

Look into putting that option in sub-note options
George

Didn't notice the dump could go full-screen at first.
George

"It would probably be useful to have a search bar".
Didn't see it on the home screen. Maybe expected it within the note too? Wants search to match within the Dump, too.
George

Tries to add content to the dump by tapping the text rather than the textbox below it.
Support for this should probably be added.
George

User struggles to tick off a list item. Expanding the hitbox to the whole block might be better.
George

"Oh the bell is a reminder! How does it remind you? What does it remind you of?"
Maybe we should highlight blocks with a notification more clearly, like by outlining/changing the colour of the block.
George

Letters in the Dump appear smaller when the screen is expanded?
George

Notebooks described as 'widgety things' -- maybe their function as 'folders' isn't super clear.
George

Praise

Likes the file structure.

"It gives a good overarching view of all your notes, which is better than other notes apps."
➔ Google Keep has a tile-based structure.
George

The little preview below note titles makes it easy to understand what's in each note.
George

Likes the text box in the dump.
George

Dump is "functional but simple".
George

Likes the ability to add images to notes.
George

"I think it's good that there's a clear button to get back, because in a lot of apps there's no clear method to leave from where you are."
George

Likes that you can show/hide the Dump.
George

File structure understood (files and sub-files).
George

Likes how the Dump is persistently-available and how the Notebooks section/file structure are all neat.
George

Likes the Dump -- Complains that lots of built-in notes apps require you to open new notes all the time.
George

Wouldn't use the dump but sees its use; compares it to having a clipboard [whiteboard?] in your house.
George

Liked the 'move block up/down' buttons because it's quicker than copy/pasting.
George

Notification button called "intuitive"; they were a fan of the notification's day/time appearing when you press the button.
George

Cheered when they were able to create a list item and tick it off.
George

Requests

Would like the ability to move pictures around with as little friction as possible.
George

App aesthetics are important -- "even something like a paper texture background could make it feel more unique".
George

Would need a dark mode (seems like it not being there would but them off using the app).
George

Requests a way to make tables.
George

[Main file structure] "It could benefit from a calendar view"

If not a calendar, maybe a list of all your active notifications and links to the relevant block?
George

Likes the idea of microphone support for note transcription/audio notes (voice memo or speech-to-text transcription).
George

Would like colour customisation.
George

"It would be useful to have the Dump adjustable in height, or have it automatically fill white space."
George

[Main file structure] "It obviously needs a way to sort."
George

Requests a free-hand/scrapbook mode where you can draw freehand, place images freely.

"I've been looking for a notes app that has fewer limitations on quickly writing things with my [Apple] Pencil."
George

Survey data/impressions

Compares toolbar to Word/a generic word processor.
George

Would mostly use the app for the Dump feature and its associated widget.
George

Uses built-in swipe-from-side back button.
George

Uses phone's built-in swipe-from-side back button.

"It reminds me of swiping pages on actual paper. It's easer than pressing buttons."
George

Would use maybe 5 notebooks, including:
- Gift ideas (I use my notes app to keep track of gifts at Christmas)
- A shopping list
- If there was a calendar I'd use that.

George

Able to guess the functionality of all the buttons on the home screen.
George

Would keep at least 3 notebooks
George

Compares the toolbar to Microsoft Word.
George

Would keep 4 notebooks:
- a planner
- essential documents/info
- birthdays/special events (planning around normal routine/meal preps)
- groceries/things to buy

George

Guesses what the Dump is accurately.

"For imminent things."
"Temporary storage."
George

Notebooks tabs "look like Twitter/Instagram stories".
George

File structure "looks like Windows files"; "It looks like Outlook." (folder/subfolder structure).

The structure is familiar to the user.
George

Uses phone's built-in swipe-from-side back button.
George

Complaints about other apps

Complains that they have a lot of unnecessary files in Apple Notes from quickly making a note that was relevant only briefly.
George

Complains about how slow it is to make a new note to write something quickly in Apple Notes.
George

Complains that on their current app, they have to make new notes for categories and can't organise notes how they'd like. The tested app is "nicely categorised and 'encapsulated'".
George

Chronic notes app user (Google Keep).

"It's [*not very good*], and I'm in the market for a new [notes app]. Keep [*is really bad*]."
George

Likes the file structure.

"It gives a good overarching view of all your notes, which is better than other notes apps."
⇒ Google Keep has a tile-based structure.
George

The main findings

The Dump was still unclear.

- Users struggled to explain what the Dump is/does.
- Users thought it might be a preview screen, or that every notebook has its own Dump.
- They were keen on the idea once they understood it and said that they would use it.
- **I had to make the Dump more visually distinct and add a draggable handle for changing the height to reduce the multitude of confusing buttons.**

The notifications feature needs fleshing out.

- Specifically how it worked was unclear, so I develop this specific feature in the high-fi prototype.

- **I decided I would make blocks with a notification attached far more prominent in the high-fidelity prototype.**

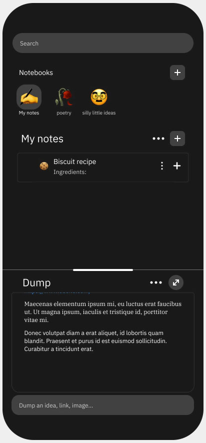
Settings screens needed.
- One user pointed out their absence; it would be useful to flesh these out in the higher-fidelity prototype.

Some of the icons were unclear.
- A number of icons on the text styles toolbar had unclear functionality.
- The controls around the Dump were confusing; There was an expand/contract button next to a fullscreen toggle button, which are confusing so close together.
  - The Dump controls would be reworked in the next version.

Someone suggested a text search within the editor.
- It was a great idea, easy to add, so I decided to add it.

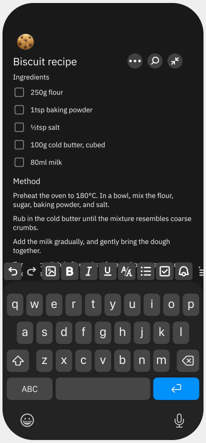
5. High-fi Prototype

[Click here to try the prototype]


Search
Notebooks
+
My notes
poetry
silly little ideas
My notes
•••
+
Biscuit recipe
Ingredients:
+
Dump
•••
Dump an idea, link, image...

Maecenas elementum ipsum mi, eu luctus erat faucibus ut. Ut magna ipsum, iaculis et tristique id, porttitor vitae mi.

Donec volutpat diam a erat aliquet, id lobortis quam blandit. Praesent et purus id est euismod sollicitudin. Curabitur a tincidunt erat.



Biscuit recipe

Ingredients

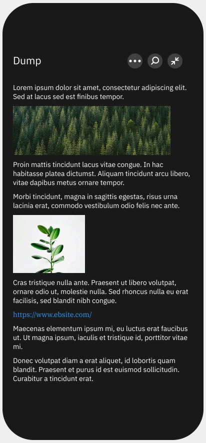
☐ 250g flour
☐ 1tsp baking powder
☐ ½tsp salt
☐ 100g cold butter, cubed
☐ 80ml milk

Method

Preheat the oven to 180°C. In a bowl, mix the flour, sugar, baking powder, and salt.

Rub in the cold butter until the mixture resembles coarse crumbs.

Add the milk gradually, and gently bring the dough together.



Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consectetur adipiscing elit. Sed at lacus sed est finibus tempor.

Proin mattis tincidunt lacus vitae congue. In hac habitasse platea dictumst. Aliquam tincidunt arcu libero, vitae dapibus metus ornare tempor.

Morbi tincidunt, magna in sagittis egestas, risus urna lacinia erat, commodo vestibulum odio felis nec ante.

Cras tristique nulla ante. Praesent ut libero volutpat, ornare odio ut, molestie nulla. Sed rhoncus nulla eu erat facilisis, sed blandit nibh congue.

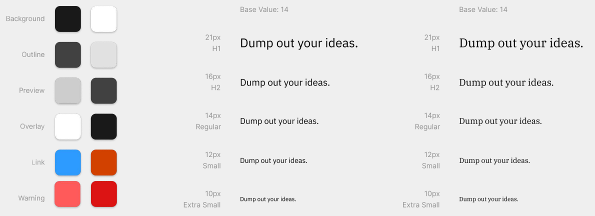
https://www.ebsite.com/

Maecenas elementum ipsum mi, eu luctus erat faucibus ut. Ut magna ipsum, iaculis et tristique id, porttitor vitae mi.

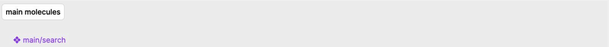
Donec volutpat diam a erat aliquet, id lobortis quam blandit. Praesent et purus id est euismod sollicitudin. Curabitur a tincidunt erat.

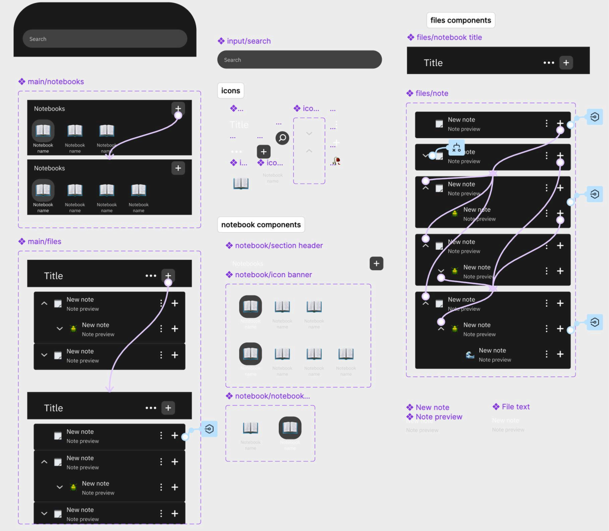
Here are a few frames from the prototype, which you can try on the link above. On the left is the main home screen, and you can see a note in the middle. If you expand the Dump, you see the screen on the right.

Design System

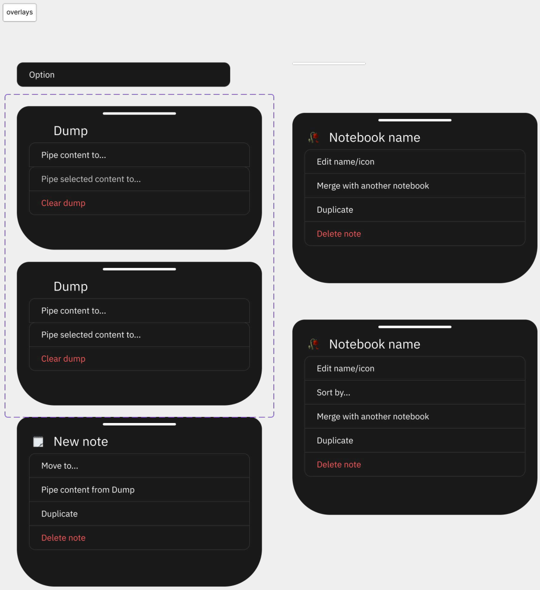

Background
Outline
Preview
Overlay
Link
Warning
Base Value: 14
21px H1
Dump out your ideas.
16px H2
Dump out your ideas.
14px Regular
Dump out your ideas.
12px Small
Dump out your ideas.
10px Extra Small
Dump out your ideas.
Base Value: 14
21px H1
Dump out your ideas.
16px H2
Dump out your ideas.
14px Regular
Dump out your ideas.
12px Small
Dump out your ideas.
10px Extra Small
Dump out your ideas.

The colours for dark mode (left) and light mode (right), and the text styles used throughout the app. There is a serif toggle function in the text editor, so the serif text is predominantly for that at this point.

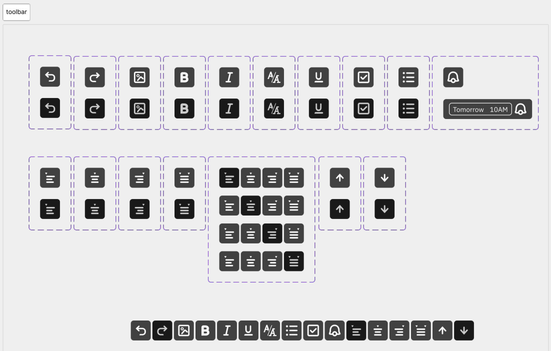

main molecules
main/search


Search
main/notebooks
Notebooks
Notebook name
main/files
Title
New note
Note preview
input/search
Search
icons
notebook components
notebook/section header
notebook/icon banner
notebook/notebook...
files components
files/notebook title
Title
files/note
New note
Note preview
File text

I took an atomic approach to building up my components. I started, above, with deciding text styles and colours, and then started to make small iconic components, and you can see how I build them into larger, more complex, interactive elements.


overlays
Option
Dump
Pipe content to...
Pipe selected content to...
Clear dump
Dump
Pipe content to...
Pipe selected content to...
Clear dump
New note
Move to...
Pipe content from Dump
Duplicate
Delete note
Notebook name
Edit name/icon
Merge with another notebook
Duplicate
Delete note
Notebook name
Edit name/icon
Sort by...
Merge with another notebook
Duplicate
Delete note

Here (☝️), I made a white line with some padding as a “handle” component and a little button for each option, and built my menu elements up from those two constituents.


toolbar
Tomorrow 10AM

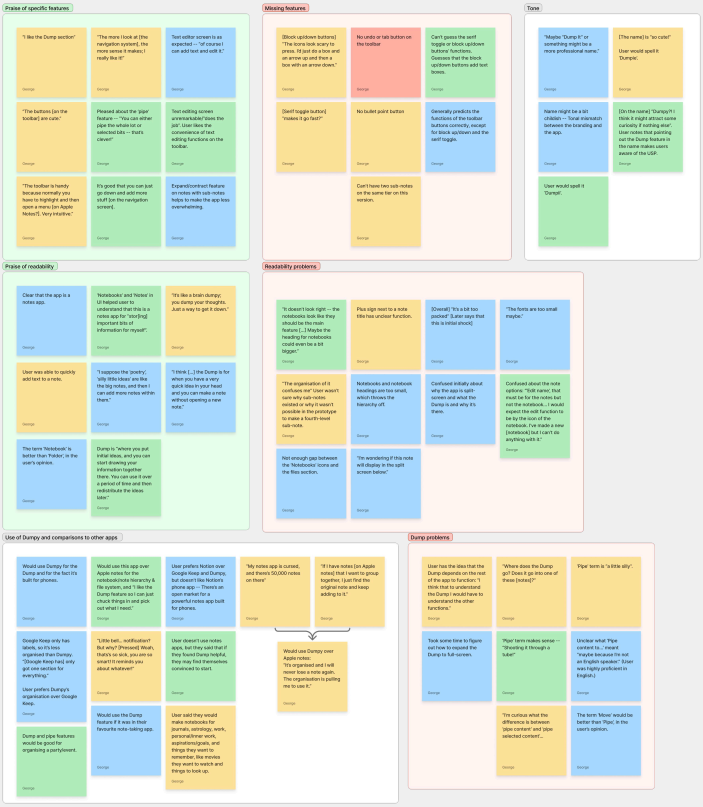
And more of the same; here I'm making the text editor toolbar. The icons are all made by me.

I combined all of these components and a few others into the main prototype. Anyway, testing time.

User testing (round 3)

3 more user tests with the same procedure as before. This time, tasks focused on:
(i) whether users can figure out what the app is/does
(ii) whether the Dump successfully explained itself
(iii) whether users can navigate the note/notebook and the hierarchy of the app
(iv) whether the text editor and the buttons within it were working as the users expected (I wasn't trying to innovate with the text editor, so it should feel comfortable, not new).

I put the findings into another affinity diagram:



Praise of specific features

"I like the Dump section"
George

"The more I look at [the navigation system], the more sense it makes; I really like it!"
George

Text editor screen is as expected -- "of course I can add text and edit it."
George

"The buttons [on the toolbar] are cute."
George

Pleased about the 'pipe' feature -- "You can either pipe the whole lot or selected bits -- that's clever!"
George

Text editing screen unremarkable/"does the job". User likes the convenience of text editing functions on the toolbar.
George

"The toolbar is handy because normally you have to highlight and then open a menu [on Apple Notes?]. Very intuitive."
George

It's good that you can just go down and add more stuff [on the navigation screen].
George

Expand/contract feature on notes with sub-notes helps to make the app less overwhelming.
George

Missing features

[Block up/down buttons] "The icons look scary to press. I'd just do a box and an arrow up and then a box with an arrow down."
George

No undo or tab button on the toolbar
George

Can't guess the serif toggle or block up/down buttons' functions. Guesses that the block up/down buttons add text boxes.
George

[Serif toggle button] "makes it go fast?"
George

No bullet point button
George

Generally predicts the functions of the toolbar buttons correctly, except for block up/down and the serif toggle.
George

Can't have two sub-notes on the same tier on this version.
George

Tone

"Maybe "Dump It" or something might be a more professional name."
George

[The name] is "so cute!"

User would spell it 'Dumpie'.
George

Name might be a bit childish -- Tonal mismatch between the branding and the app.
George

[On the name] "Dumpy?! I think it might attract some curiosity if nothing else". User notes that pointing out the Dump feature in the name makes users aware of the USP.
George

User would spell it 'Dumpii'.
George

Praise of readability

Clear that the app is a notes app.
George

'Notebooks' and 'Notes' in UI helped user to understand that this is a notes app for "stor[ing] important bits of information for myself".
George

"It's like a brain dumpy; you dump your thoughts. Just a way to get it down."
George

User was able to quickly add text to a note.
George

"I suppose the 'poetry', 'silly little ideas' are like the big notes, and then I can add more notes within them."
George

"I think [...] the Dump is for when you have a very quick idea in your head and you can make a note without opening a new note."
George

The term 'Notebook' is better than 'Folder', in the user's opinion.
George

Dump is "where you put initial ideas, and you can start drawing your information together there. You can use it over a period of time and then redistribute the ideas later."
George

Readability problems

"It doesn't look right -- the notebooks look like they should be the main feature [...] Maybe the heading for notebooks could even be a bit bigger."
George

Plus sign next to a note title has unclear function.
George

[Overall] "It's a bit too packed" [Later says that this is initial shock]
George

"The fonts are too small maybe."
George

"The organisation of it confuses me" User wasn't sure why sub-notes existed or why it wasn't possible in the prototype to make a fourth-level sub-note.
George

Notebooks and notebook headings are too small, which throws the hierarchy off.
George

Confused initially about why the app is split-screen and what the Dump is and why it's there.
George

Confused about the note options: "'Edit name', that must be for the notes but not the notebook... I would expect the edit function to be by the icon of the notebook. I've made a new [notebook] but I can't do anything with it."
George

Not enough gap between the 'Notebooks' icons and the files section.
George

"I'm wondering if this note will display in the split screen below."
George

Use of Dumpy and comparisons to other apps

Would use Dumpy for the Dump and for the fact it's built for phones.
George

Would use this app over Apple notes for the notebook/note hierarchy & file system, and "I like the Dump feature so I can just chuck things in and pick out what I need."
George

User prefers Notion over Google Keep and Dumpy, but doesn't like Notion's phone app -- There's an open market for a powerful notes app built for phones.
George

"My notes app is cursed, and there's 50,000 notes on there"
George

"If I have notes [on Apple notes] that I want to group together, I just find the original note and keep adding to it."
George

Would use Dumpy over Apple notes:
"It's organised and I will never lose a note again. The organisation is pulling me to use it."
George

Google Keep only has labels, so it's less organised than Dumpy. "[Google Keep has] only got one section for everything."

User prefers Dumpy's organisation over Google Keep.
George

"Little bell... notification? But why? [Pressed] Woah, thats's so sick, you are so smart! It reminds you about whatever!"
George

User doesn't use notes apps, but they said that if they found Dump helpful, they may find themselves convinced to start.
George

Dump and pipe features would be good for organising a party/event.
George

Would use the Dump feature if it was in their favourite note-taking app.
George

User said they would make notebooks for journals, astrology, work, personal/inner work, aspirations/goals, and things they want to remember, like movies they want to watch and things to look up.
George

Dump problems

User has the idea that the Dump depends on the rest of the app to function: "I think that to understand the Dump I would have to understand the other functions."
George

"Where does the Dump go? Does it go into one of these [notes]?"
George

'Pipe' term is "a little silly".
George

Took some time to figure out how to expand the Dump to full-screen.
George

'Pipe' term makes sense -- "Shooting it through a tube!"
George

Unclear what 'Pipe content to...' meant "maybe because I'm not an English speaker." (User was highly proficient in English.)
George

"I'm curious what the difference is between 'pipe content' and 'pipe selected content'...
George

The term 'Move' would be better than 'Pipe', in the user's opinion.
George

The main findings

The Dump was finally (almost) successful.

- Some users finally grasped the concept quickly.
- Others still struggled to see how it was distinct from (or related to) the notebooks section above it. **I would separate the Dump from the rest of the app even further in the final version.**
- One user didn't understand what "pipe content" meant. This is a powerful feature of the Dump, so **it might be worth using more plain language for this**.

Some readability issues with the toolbar.

- The block up/down buttons and the serif toggle were new concepts to many users. As they were, the buttons looked overly complex and metaphorical, and one said that this made them "scary".
- **I'll simplify these icons and try to make their function clearer or, if not, at least less scary.**

The screen is crowded.

- Initial impressions of the app created anxiety in users. I deduced that there may be too many thin lines. The app is, admittedly, complicated, so over-complicating it fresh eyes just with meaningless lines is not ideal.

- **I'll strip the design down to improve readability.**

The tone was off.

- The app had a silly name and was covered in silly emojis, but something about it felt too serious to users.
- **I'll inject more *branding* into the app to give it a more clear identity and make it feel less like professional software (great for power users, not for new users).**

More great suggestions.

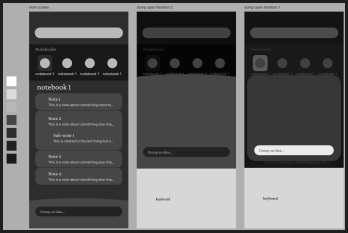
- The toolbar was missing a bullet point function and (crucially) an undo button.
- **I'll add those.**

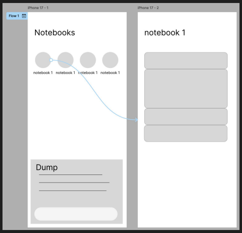
6. Finalise

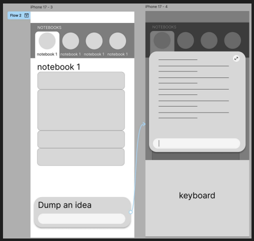
Taking stock

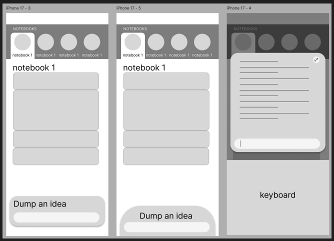
With everything I've learnt, it's time to think up some final solutions for the problems uncovered from the user tests, and build a more functional prototype. In this section, I experiment with AI much more for generating ideas and coding for me.

Back to the drawing board


main screen
dump open iteration 2
dump open iteration 1
Notebooks
notebook 1
Note 1
Note 2
Sub-note 1
Note 3
Note 4
Dump an idea...
keyboard


Flow 1
iPhone 17 - 1
iPhone 17 - 2
Notebooks
notebook 1
Dump


Flow 2
iPhone 17 - 3
iPhone 17 - 4
NOTEBOOKS
notebook 1
Dump an idea
keyboard

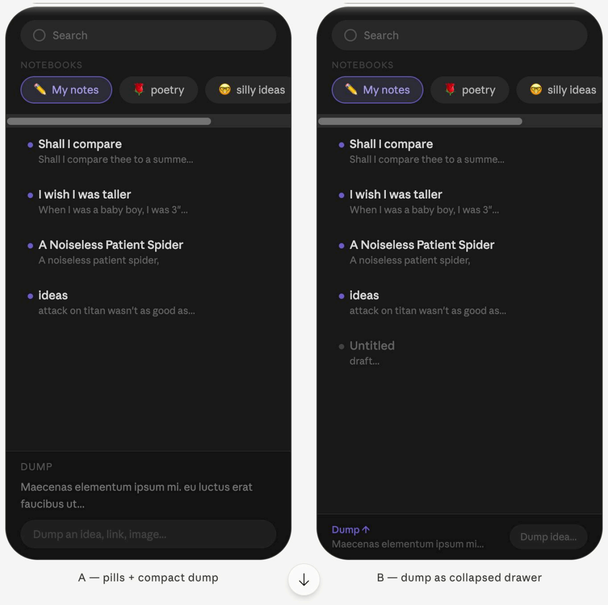

iPhone 17 - 3
iPhone 17 - 5
iPhone 17 - 4
NOTEBOOKS
notebook 1
Dump an idea
keyboard

I laid out a few new wireframes to come up with solutions to (i) reduce the visual noise, (ii) more distinctly separate the Dump and (iii) lighten the mood of the app.

In iteration 1 (top left) I introduce the idea of bubble-ifying the whole design of the app. The idea is that on the home page, the user has a lot of different bubbles that they can expand and contract, and the Dump is one of these.

Iteration 2 (top right) removes notes from the home page and the Dump from notebooks, reducing visual noise at the cost of some split-second access to some parts of the app, depending on where you are.

Iterations 3 & 4 (bottom) consolidate the high-fi prototype and build on iteration 1 by introducing clearer tabs to show where the user is, and the idea of the Dump as a bubble that overlays the usual app, rather than as a note almost indistinguishable from any other.


Search
NOTEBOOKS
My notes
poetry
silly ideas

Shall I compare
Shall I compare thee to a summe...

I wish I was taller
When I was a baby boy, I was 3"...

A Noiseless Patient Spider
A noiseless patient spider,

ideas
attack on titan wasn't as good as...

DUMP

Maecenas elementum ipsum mi. eu luctus erat faucibus ut...

Dump an idea, link, image...

Untitled
draft...

Dump

Maecenas elementum ipsum mi...

Dump idea...

A — pills + compact dump

B — dump as collapsed drawer

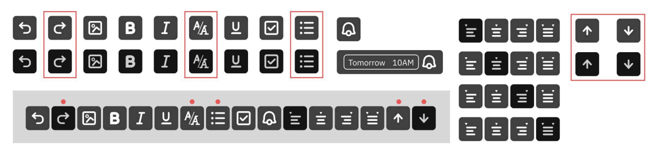
I also started experimenting with using AI to iterate.
This iteration from *Claude* had a really clean edge-to-edge note with no clear borders around the notes, but it remains obvious where the user should tap. The Dump and the file explorer are also different colours, distinguishing really effectively.

Rebranding

At this time I also worked on finding some nicer fonts to improve the "friendliness" of the app.

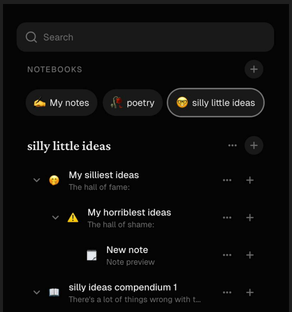
I decided to use this font, Crimson Pro, for headings and for the serif-toggled text in the text editor, and this font, Rubik, for prose, descriptions and subtext.

These fonts were readable and a little more playful than the IBM Plex fonts that I was initially using, and added a lot of warmth and personality to the app.


Tomorrow 10AM

I also changed the toolbar so that the icons that previously weren't working were replaced with more intuitive options.

AI-assisted building

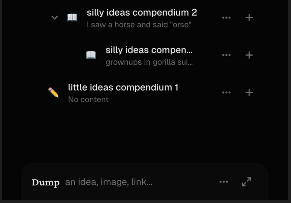

Search
NOTEBOOKS
My notes
poetry
silly little ideas
silly little ideas

My silliest ideas
The hall of fame:

My horriblest ideas
The hall of shame:

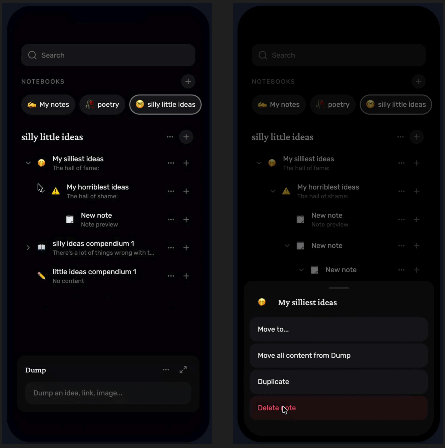
New note
Note preview

silly ideas compendium 1
There's a lot of things wrong with t...


silly ideas compendium 2
I saw a horse and said "orse"
silly ideas compen...
grownups in gorilla sui...
little ideas compendium 1
No content
Dump
an idea, image, link...

Here, I made an interactive prototype with *v0*.

I fed in the ideas from Claude and prompted *v0* to alter the fonts and colours in a way that better matched my branding and showed the proper file hierarchy again.
It showed how powerful generative AI tools can be for quickly making more interactive web-based prototypes.
(*v0* prototype available here)


Search
NOTEBOOKS
My notes
poetry
silly little ideas
silly little ideas
My silliest ideas
The hall of fame:
My horriblest ideas
The hall of shame:
New note
Note preview
silly ideas compendium 1
There's a lot of things wrong with t...
little ideas compendium 1
No content
Dump
Dump an idea, link, image...
Search
NOTEBOOKS
My notes
poetry
silly little ideas
silly little ideas
My silliest ideas
The hall of fame:
My horriblest ideas
The hall of shame:
New note
Note preview
New note
New note
My silliest ideas
Move to...
Move all content from Dump
Duplicate
Delete note

I developed the prototype with *Figma Make*.

I fed the *v0* prototype into *Figma Make* and developed it into a prototype of an ideal final product. I was able to make a near-complete, fully-functional demo with relative ease. This could be used to show the product to stakeholders, and the generated code could be used to make the software engineering process faster and easier.
(*Figma Make* prototype available here)

And that's a wrap!

After a lot of toil, testing, drawing, drafting, brainstorming and building, I decided to call an end to the project there. As a summary of the process:

- I **conceptualised** a super-fast notes app with minimal friction, and conducted research into competitor apps and their users.
- I planned and crafted **wireframes**, and **tested users** to understand the good and bad aspects of the user experience at various points throughout the project. I then **used their feedback to inform further development**.
- I refined my wireframes into **low-fi and high-fi prototypes**, using **atomic design principles** to make sure that my **design systems** were easy to work with, and easy to build with.
- I used **agentive AI** to brainstorm new ideas, and to build more highly-functional prototypes, and ultimately a near-complete demo of the final product.

7. Learnings

User research works wonders

While not strictly news to me, I was surprised and impressed at how much the users I interviewed were able to steer the project towards something far more intuitive and useful than my first plan.

Atomic design

One of my goals with this project was to make a more complex design system than I’d ever built before, and to use atomic design to do it cleanly. It was a great learning exercise for me, and I came out confident with building components with other components.

This also allowed me to get more involved with Figma variables and styles, which helped to keep my design consistent across the app. I even made an easily toggle-able dark/light mode that unfortunately just didn’t make it into any of the prototypes.

AI is powerful

I had the chance to test out a range of agentic tools to work with it to see what they could do for *Dumpy*. I learnt the foibles of a few popular tools, and found that they can be powerful, and that I shouldn’t be shy to employ them to speed up the process sometimes. With the right guidance, AI tools can multiply a UX designer’s productivity.